

MOOD IN SOCIETY

SML QUARTERLY NEWSLETTER

Welcome to the August edition of Mood in Society

Dear Readers,

These past few months we explored a few moods all with one common theme. A theme that quietly shapes our everyday lives: the spaces we inhabit and how they influence our sense of belonging, connection and wellbeing. From public parks and city streets to football fields and digital platforms, the places where we gather are more than physical settings, they shape how we interact, form relationships and experience society.

In this edition, we examine three interconnected moods. We begin by exploring how *safety and gender influence access to leisure and public spaces*. We then turn to the changing landscape of *youth dating, where shrinking third spaces and digital deception are reshaping how young people connect*. Finally, we reflect on *football as more than a game, considering its role as a powerful space for recreation, identity formation and masculine socialization*.

Although these topics may seem different, they are united by a common question: What makes a space truly safe, welcoming and meaningful for everyone?

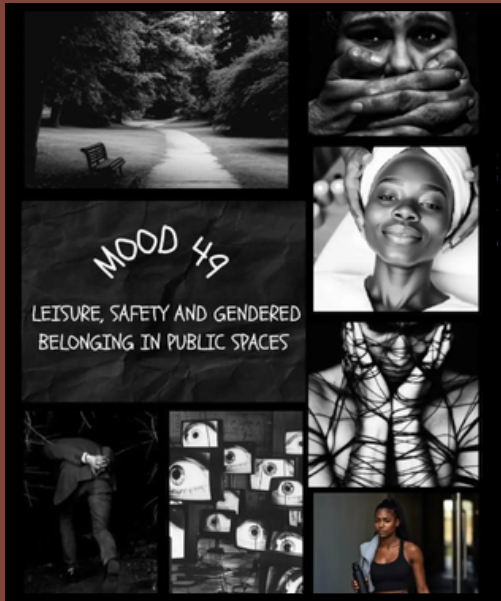
As always, thank you for reading, sharing your perspectives and contributing to the conversations across the Mood in Society community. Your engagement continues to enrich these discussions and reminds us that understanding the social mood is a collective journey.

Editor Dr. Pumla Nofemele



FEATURED MOOD 49.

LEISURE, SAFETY AND GENDERED BELONGING IN PUBLIC SPACES.



Leisure is often associated with rest, freedom and wellbeing. But what happens when simply occupying a public space requires constant vigilance?

In Mood 49, we examined how gender shapes experiences of leisure in South Africa, arguing that for many women and girls, recreation is overshadowed by the need to navigate harassment, violence and fear. From parks and sports grounds to digital platforms, spaces intended for relaxation frequently demand continuous risk assessment, limiting opportunities for genuine rest and belonging.

The article asks readers to reconsider whether leisure can truly fulfil its purpose when safety is unequally experienced. It concludes with an important question: Who has the freedom to enjoy public space, and what would it take to create leisure environments where everyone can participate with dignity, safety and a genuine sense of belonging?

FEATURED MOOD 50.

YOUTH DATING, FRAGILE THIRD SPACES & DIGITAL DECEPTION



Where do young people meet today? Increasingly, the answer lies in digital spaces rather than the parks, cafés and community gathering places that once fostered face to face connections. In this podcast, we explored how the decline of traditional "third spaces" and the rise of online dating are reshaping trust, relationships and belonging. From curated profiles and catfishing to broader forms of digital deception, the conversation examines the opportunities and risks of modern dating while asking an important question: How do young people build genuine connections in a world where digital interactions have become the new meeting place?

FEATURED MOOD 51.

FOOTBALL, RECREATION & MASCULINE SOCIALIZATION



Whilst the 2026 FIFA World Cup captured global attention, Mood 51 looked beyond the game to explore football's role as a powerful space for recreation, identity and socialization.

Football provides millions of boys and men with opportunities for belonging, hope, teamwork and community, it also shapes ideas about what it means to "be a man."

Drawing on South African experiences, this theme considers how football can both foster positive values such as resilience and brotherhood while also reinforcing harmful masculine norms.

Ultimately, it asks an important question: What kind of masculinity is football helping to cultivate, and how can these spaces contribute to healthier, more inclusive forms of manhood?

FROM THE FIELD

In May, I attended an online seminar hosted by the Human Sciences Research Council (HSRC) on the Draft White Paper on Local Government (WPLG26): Enhancing Urban Development and More Sustainable Human Settlements.

During the discussion, I raised a question about the role municipalities could play in supporting long term unemployed adults who have aged out of youth targeted programmes. I asked whether community infrastructure could be reimagined as spaces for skills activation, peer-led initiatives, and meaningful community participation, recognising unemployment as both a social and spatial challenge.

While the discussion centred primarily on improving municipal systems and governance rather than issue-specific interventions, it highlighted an important lesson: policy conversations often focus on strengthening institutions, while the lived experiences of exclusion, belonging, and community wellbeing can receive less attention.

It reinforced my belief that unemployment is not only an economic issue. It is also a question of social connection, dignity, and place. As discussions on sustainable human settlements continue, I hope future policy debates will increasingly recognise the value of community spaces not only as physical infrastructure, but as places that foster participation, wellbeing, and social inclusion.



socialmoodlabel Mood 49. Leisure, Safety, and Gendered Belonging in Public Spaces. 🐦🐦🐦🐦

- 1 We were watching All Her Fault, and the interactions between Jenny & her husband Richie caught our attention. Throughout the show, there is a clear pattern, his time is his own, but hers is always interrupted.
- 2 When she finally confronts him, she names what many women experience: she cannot relax because she is always on call. Her time is never fully hers.
- 3 This moment mirrors an integral part of our theme, that is Mood 49. Women's leisure is not leisure at all. It is interrupted, conditional, and shaped by traditional gender norms. For many women, leaving the house is not indulgence, it is survival, rest, or escape from emotional strain at home.

wherewellnessgrows How we intersect socially has changed dramatically and I love your message about bringing back those spaces where organic conversation and connection exist

9w 1 like Reply

socialmoodlabel @wherewellnessgrows means a lot

9w 1 like Reply

Hide replies

silkbath.ae Love this one! 🍷

8w 1 like Reply

View replies (1)

solosipsandsoftness Exactly this! 🍷

8w 1 like Reply

View replies (1)

vayu.co This a great point to be made 🍷 The digital world is only a fragment of reality

8w 1 like Reply

mydailymindfuel Such important information! 🍷

9w 1 like Reply

space is restricted. Public spaces are hostile. Rest requires vigilance

igise; promising to "do better" was wrong, but because women are asking for time, space, and rest.

dignity, not demand justification. me off, we want to Belong, Safely,

addwingstoyoursoul Thank you for focusing on this unfortunately important topic 🍷

17w 1 like Reply

View replies (1)

socialmoodlabel The fact that "will I make it home tonight?" is a thought so many of us have had, in a library, out for a jog, at a late dinner, on the way to the POST OFFICE, says everything. We deserve better than just surviving public spaces. 🍷

17w 3 likes Reply

socialmoodlabel I've run through that checklist more times than I can count. Let's keep having this conversation, silence doesn't make us safer even now that GBVF has been declared a National disaster, same same same

17w 3 likes Reply

View replies (2)

salitter.wellness Everyone deserves the simple right to move, rest, and exist without compromise 🍷

17w 1 like Reply

View replies (1)

signs.we.ignore Safety shouldn't require strategy

17w 1 like Reply

#masculinity #football #fifaworldcup2026 #recreation #mood

1w

solosipsandsoftness Great post! 🍷

6d 1 like Reply

soft_reminders_ 🍷

1w 1 like Reply

mindfulsvccss Great share 🍷

6d 1 like Reply

channels_of_wisdom My son loves your page 🍷

1w 1 like Reply

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reilysworld Supa strikas 🍷